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**Debate Pack**
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# Eating Disorders Awareness Week 2024

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# 1 Background

Eating disorders are serious mental health conditions that can have severe psychological, physical and social consequences. An eating disorder can involve eating too much, or too little, getting rid of food that has been eaten or a combination of these behaviours. Those with eating disorders may have negative perceptions of their body image, such as their weight and shape, and often have other mental health problems alongside the eating disorder, such as anxiety or depression.[1] Eating disorders commonly start in adolescence but can start earlier or later during childhood or adulthood.[2]

The NHS identifies the following symptoms of eating disorders:

- spending a lot of time worrying about your weight and body shape
- avoiding socialising when you think food will be involved
- eating very little food
- making yourself sick or taking laxatives after you eat
- exercising too much
- having very strict habits or routines around food
- changes in your mood such as being withdrawn, anxious or depressed

Individuals may also notice physical signs, including:

- feeling cold, tired or dizzy
- pains, tingling or numbness in your arms and legs (poor circulation)
- feeling your heart racing, fainting or feeling faint
- problems with your digestion, such as bloating, constipation or diarrhoea
- your weight being very high or very low for someone of your age and height
- not getting your period or other delayed signs of puberty.[3]

The National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) published an updated clinical guideline on the recognition and treatment of eating disorders in December 2020 which provides the following definition:

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1 NHS England, Children and young people's eating disorders programme, not dated [accessed on 25 February 2024]

2 NICE guideline [NG69], Eating disorders: recognition and treatment, updated 16 December 2020

3 NHS, Overview – Eating Disorders, last accessed 25 February 2024

> [Eating disorders are] defined by the negative beliefs and behaviours they cause people to have about themselves and their eating, body shape and weight. They can cause people to adopt restricted eating, binge eating and compensatory behaviours (such as vomiting and excessive exercise). The emotional and physical consequences of these beliefs and behaviours maintain the disorder and result in a high mortality rate from malnutrition, suicide and physical issues (such as electrolyte imbalances). This is most common in people with anorexia nervosa. There are also other physical complications (such as osteoporosis) and psychiatric comorbidities (such as anxiety disorders) that affect the wellbeing and recovery of people with an eating disorder and raise the cost of treatment.[4]

## 1.1 Eating Disorders Awareness Week, 26 February – 3 March 2024

Eating Disorders Awareness Week is an international event for raising awareness and understanding of eating disorders, challenging stereotypes and stigmas.

This year the UK eating disorder charity Beat is focusing on avoidant/restrictive food intake disorder (ARFID), which is a condition characterised by the person avoiding certain foods or types of food, having restricted intake in terms of overall amount eaten, or both.[5]

## 1.2 Statistics

NHS England's survey on the Mental Health of Children and Young People in England provides information on prevalence and trends in eating disorders and possible eating problems among this group.[6] This survey was first undertaken in 2017 and followed up in 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023.

### Eating disorder prevalence

Prevalence estimates for clinically diagnosed eating disorders were first produced as part of the 2017 survey and updated in 2023. The survey's findings show that eating disorder prevalence is on the rise:

- The proportion of 11 to 16-year-olds with an eating disorder increased from 0.5% in 2017 to 2.6% in 2023.

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4 NICE guideline [NG69], Eating disorders: recognition and treatment, updated 16 December 2020

5 Beat, Eating Disorder Awareness Week 2024

6 NHS Digital, Mental Health of Children and Young People in England

- Rates were higher among 17 to 19-year-olds, rising from 0.8% in 2017 to 12.5% in 2023.
- Young people aged 20 to 25 were first included in the 2023 survey, when 5.9% of this age group was found to have an eating disorder.[7]

The table below shows prevalence estimates for different types of eating disorder.

**Eating disorder prevalence among children and young people**
% with a clinical diagnosis, England, 2023

| Age group | Anorexia nervosa | Bulimia nervosa | Other eating disorders | **Any eating disorder** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 11 to 16 year olds | 0.2% | 0.5% | 1.8% | **2.6%** |
| 17 to 19 year olds | 3.3% | 1.7% | 7.8% | **12.5%** |
| 20 to 25 year olds | 0.3% | 1.8% | 4.2% | **5.9%** |

Source: NHS Digital, Children and Young People's Mental Health in England 2023, Table 5.4

In 2023, rates of eating disorders in 11 to 16-year-olds were found to be four times higher in girls (4.3%) than boys (1.0%). The same was true among 17 to 19-year-olds (20.8% for girls and 5.1% for boys).

The difference was less pronounced between young women and men aged 20 to 25.

Similar estimates are not available for other UK nations.

Information on eating disorder prevalence among adults is not routinely collected. NICE provides a summary of available research on its website.[8]

### Risk of possible eating problems

NHS England's survey also asked children and young people the following questions about feelings towards eating and body shape to screen for possible eating problems:

| Questions asked about feelings towards eating and body shape |
|---|
| Have you ever thought you were fat even when other people told you that you were very thin? |
| Would you be ashamed if other people knew how much you eat? |
| Have you ever deliberately made yourself vomit (throw up)? |

[7] NHS Digital, Children and Young People's Mental Health in England 2023, Table 5.4
[8] NICE, Eating disorders: How common is it?, July 2019

| |
|---|
| Do worries about eating (such as: What to eat? Where to eat? How much to eat?) really interfere with your life? |
| If you eat too much, do you blame yourself a lot? |

Source: NHS Digital, Mental Health of Children and Young People in England 2023: Questionnaire and materials, p64 and 104

Those who answered 'yes' to two or more questions were classed as having 'screened positive' for a possible eating problem. Screening positive is not a formal diagnosis of an eating disorder but indicates an increased likelihood of problems with eating.

These questions were followed up in the 2021, 2022 and 2023 surveys, which found that the proportion of children and young people screening positive for possible eating problems has also increased.

Among 11 to 16-year-olds, 12.3% screened positive in 2023, up from 6.7% in 2017. Among 17 to 19-year-olds, the likelihood of screening positive was markedly higher: 59.4% in 2023, up from 44.6% in 2017.

In both age groups, girls were more likely to screen positive, but there was also a rise among boys between 2017 and 2023.

The table below shows the proportion of children and young people who people screened positive in 2023, broken down by age and sex.

**Children and young people with possible eating problems**

% who screened positive for possible eating problems, England, 2023

| Age group | Girls | Boys | **All** |
|---|---|---|---|
| 11 to 16 year olds | 14.9% | 9.8% | **12.3%** |
| 17 to 19 year olds | 77.5% | 42.3% | **59.4%** |
| 20 to 25 year olds | 72.3% | 43.0% | **57.2%** |

Source: NHS Digital, Children and Young People's Mental Health in England 2023, Table 5.1

## Hospital admissions

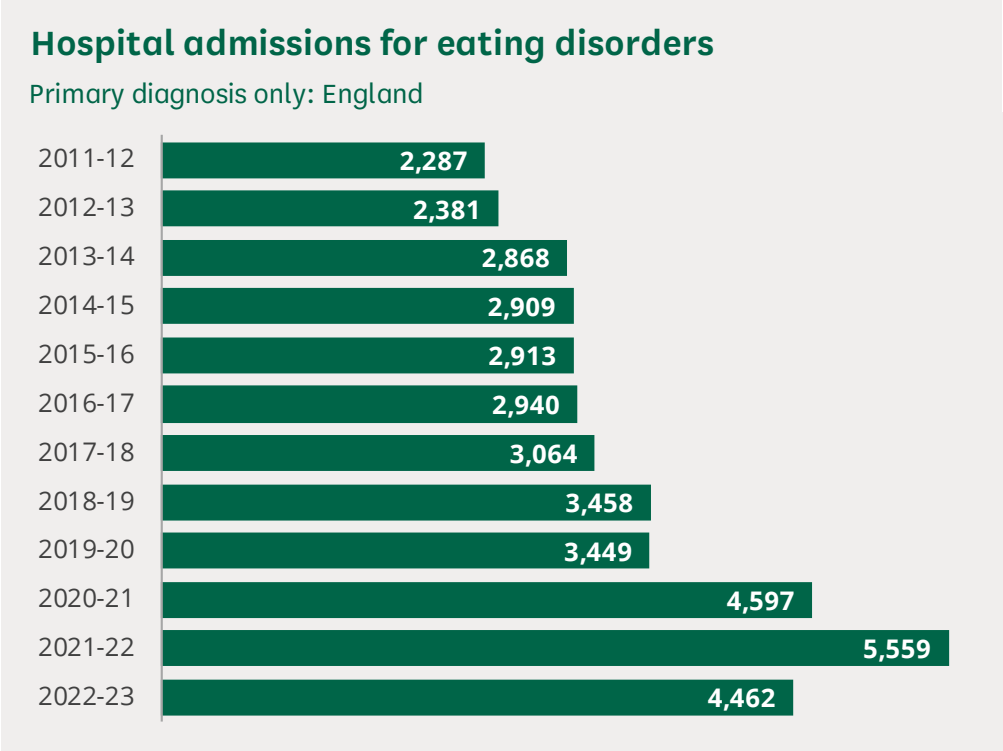
NHS Digital publishes data on hospital admissions in England, by reason for admission (diagnosis).[9]

The chart below shows that the number of hospital admissions where the primary diagnosis was an eating disorder has doubled over the past decade.

[9] NHS Digital, Hospital Admitted Patient Care Activity, 2022-23

"Primary diagnosis" means that an eating disorder was recorded as the main reason for the admission.

In the 2022/23 financial year there were 4,462 hospital admissions for eating disorders, up from 2,287 in 2011/12. The majority (81%) of admissions in 2022/23 were emergency admissions.



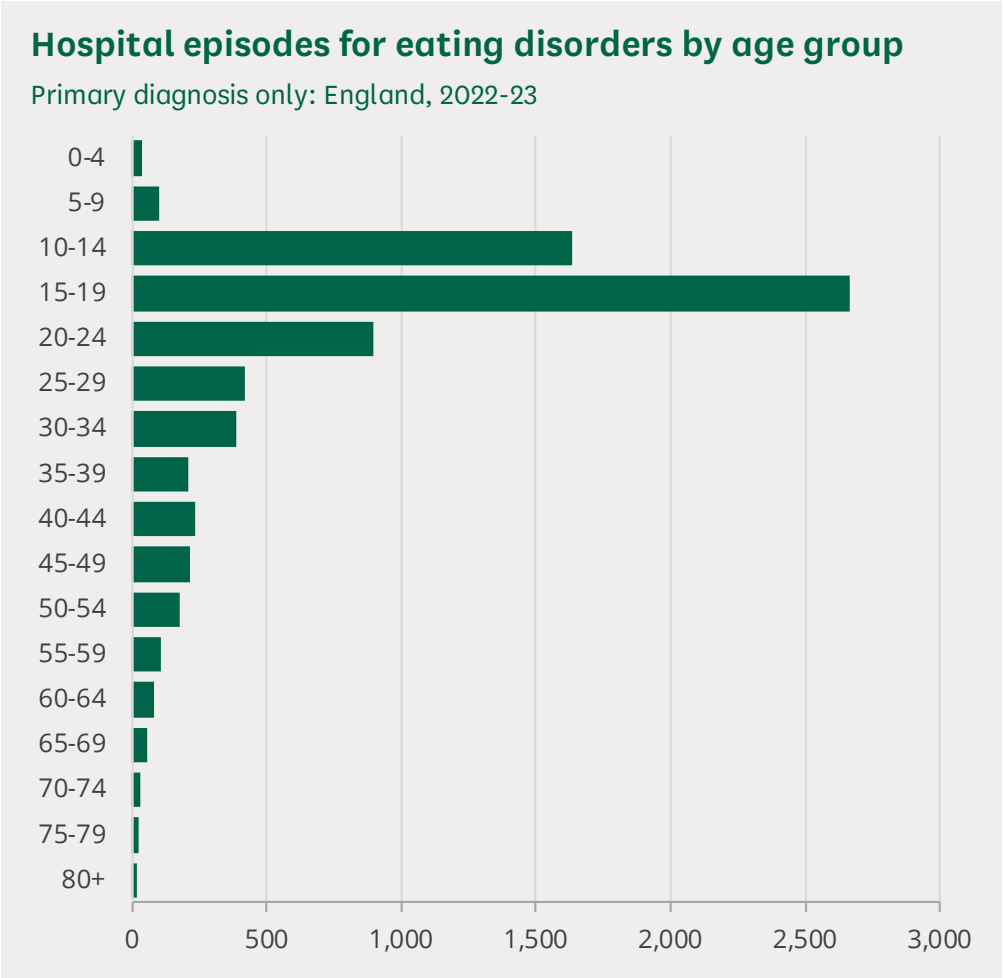

Source: NHS Digital, Hospital Admitted Patient Care Activity (various editions), diagnosis tables

In 2022/23, female patients accounted for 91% of hospital episodes where the primary diagnosis was an eating disorder.[10]

15 to 19-year-olds were the age group with the highest number of episodes, accounting for 40% of all episodes. The average (mean) age of patients was 23.

The chart below shows hospital episodes where the primary diagnosis was an eating disorder, broken down by age group.

[10] Hospital episodes are different to hospital admissions. Each episode relates to a continuous period of care for a patient under a single consultant at a single hospital. An admission may include more than one episode.




Source: NHS Digital, Hospital Admitted Patient Care Activity (various editions), diagnosis tables

Data on patients admitted to hospital with an eating disorder diagnosis in Scotland is included in a report by the Scottish Parliament Information Centre.[11]

Hospital admissions data for Wales is published by Digital Health and Care Wales.[12]

Data for Northern Ireland is included in the acute episode-based activity statistics release published by the Department of Health.[13]

## Waiting times for eating disorder services

A new national waiting times standard for children and young people with an eating disorder came into force in April 2017. The waiting time target is that

[11] SPICe briefing, Eating Disorders in Scotland, June 2022

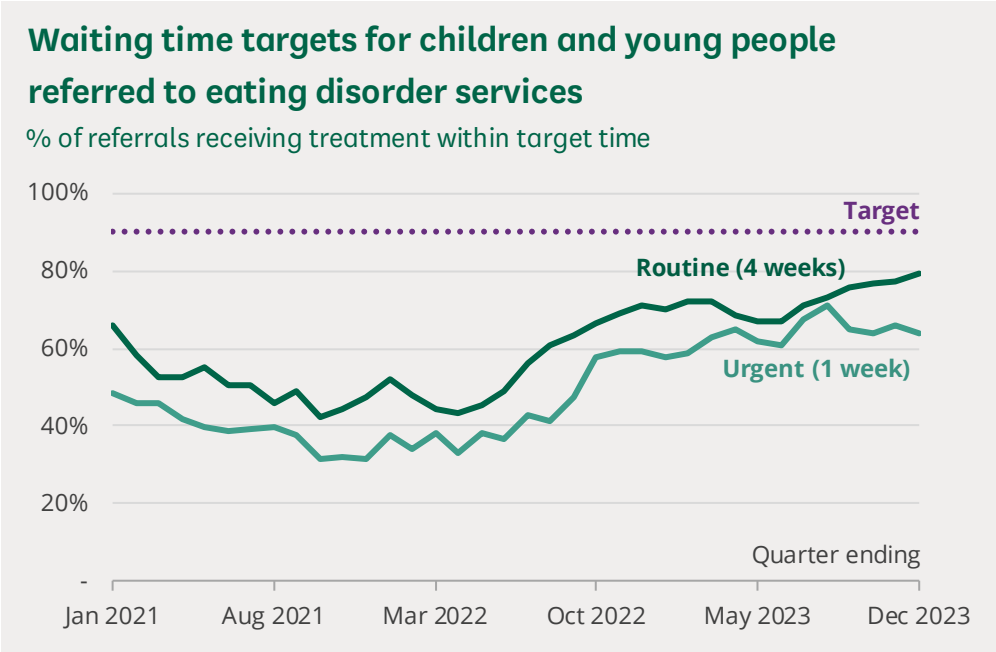
[12] Digital Health and Care Wales, Annual Hospital Admissions Data

[13] Northern Ireland Department of Health, Acute episode-based activity statistics 2022/23

from 2020 onwards, 95% of urgent cases should receive treatment within one week and 95% of routine cases should receive treatment within four weeks.[14]

These targets are not yet being met. The latest data shows that an estimated 64% of urgent referrals were seen within one week and 79% of routine referrals were seen within four weeks in October to December 2023.[15] Performance on these measures fell during 2020 and 2021 but has since recovered. The chart below shows trends from 2021 onwards.

Waiting time statistics for other UK nations are not routinely published.




Source: NHS Digital, Mental Health Services Monthly Statistics: December 2023, Time series csv file

## 1.3 Recent policy and funding

### Funding

Most recently, the Government has said that funding for children and young people's services for eating disorders will rise to an extra £54 million per year from 2023/24, creating more capacity for people to receive support.[16]

[14] NHS England, Access and Waiting Time Standard for Children and Young People with an Eating Disorder (PDF), July 2015

[15] NHS Digital, Mental Health Services Monthly Statistics: December 2023, Time series csv file

[16] PQ 181237 [on Eating Disorders, Health Services], 18 April 2023

Additional funding for eating disorder services was also discussed during a debate on Children's Mental Health Week 2024.[17]

The NHS Long Term Plan (January 2019) set out measures to improve the provision of, and access to, mental health services, including an investment for mental health services of at least £2.3 billion a year by 2023/24.

The Long Term Plan committed to boosting investment specifically in children and young people's eating disorder services over a five-year period.

The plan noted that investment would mean an additional two million people, including 345,000 children and young people, could access NHS funded mental health support and school or college-based Mental Health Support Teams.[18] It also committed to investment over five years to meet waiting time standards for children and young people's eating disorder services (see below).

The Long Term Plan explained that new models of care would enable an additional 370,000 adults and older adults to have greater choice and control over their care, and be supported to live well in the community.[19]

In March 2021, the Government announced that £79 million would be allocated to increase mental health support services for children and young people, considering rising rates of mental health problems following the COVID-19 pandemic and lockdown.[20] This would allow:

- Nearly 3 million children in England to be supported by mental health support teams in schools
- Around 22,500 more children and young people to access community mental health services
- 2,000 more children and young people to access eating disorder services

This funding forms part of the £500 million for mental health announced at the 2021 to 2022 spending review.[21]

The Covid-19 Mental Health and Wellbeing Recovery Action Plan (March 2021) also set out an investment of £58 million to accelerate the roll-out of the community mental health framework to treat adults and older adults with serious mental illness. This focuses on transforming eating disorder

[17] HC Deb 30 January 2024 c275WH
[18] NHS England, NHS Long Term Plan, 7 January 2019, para 3.25
[19] As above, para 3.94
[20] Department of Health and Social Care, £79 million to boost mental health support for children and young people, 5 March 2021
[21] Department of Health and Social Care, £79 million to boost mental health support for children and young people, 5 March 2021

pathways, with an emphasis on early intervention and collaboration between voluntary and community sector partners.

### Major conditions strategy

In April 2022, the Government launched a discussion paper and call for evidence to inform a new cross-government, ten-year plan for mental health and wellbeing in England. This was part of the Government's commitment set out in the Levelling Up White Paper (February 2022) to address unequal outcomes across the country.

In January 2023, it was announced that mental health would be incorporated into a new major conditions strategy, instead of a stand-alone plan. [22] The strategy has an overall objective of gaining 5 extra years of healthy life expectancy by 2035 and narrowing the gap in healthy life expectancy by 2030 and covers six major conditions (cancers, cardiovascular diseases, chronic respiratory diseases, dementia, mental ill health and musculoskeletal disorders).

The Government notes that the responses to the mental health plan call for evidence will directly inform the development of the major conditions strategy.[23]

In response, the President of the Royal College of Psychiatrists said:

> While we welcome the new strategy, we are disappointed that the Government has abandoned the cross-government mental health and wellbeing plan. We are at a critical moment for mental health services. Last year we reached record levels of referrals, and I have seen first-hand the enormous pressure services are under.[24]

The Major Conditions Strategy is expected to be published later in 2024.[25]

### Online Safety Act 2023

The Government is also tackling online harms through the Online Safety Act 2023. The Act establishes a new regulatory regime to address illegal and harmful content online, and is intended to help tackle online content that encourages and facilitates eating disorders, self-harm and suicide. For further information, see the House of Commons Library briefing on Analysis of the Online Safety Bill (April 2022).

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22 WS HCWS514 24 January 2023, Government Action on Major Conditions and Diseases

23 PQ 188628 [on Mental Health Services], 8 June 2023

24 Royal College of Psychiatrists, RCPsych respond to new strategy on major conditions and diseases, 24 January 2023

25 PQ 12136 [on Mental Health Services: Children and Young People], 30 January 2024

## Education

There have been programmes to strengthen partnerships between education providers and mental health services.

In January 2017, the Prime Minister announced that every secondary school in England would be offered mental health first aid training over three years; the programme sees teachers receive practical advice on how to deal with a range of mental health issues, including eating disorders.[26]

One of the key proposals of the Green Paper on Transforming children and young people's mental health provision was to create new Mental Health Support Teams for schools and colleges. The Government provided a recent update on the roll out of this programme:

> As of April 2023, MHSTs covered 47% of pupils in secondary schools in England. The department is extending coverage of MHSTs to an estimated 44% of pupils and learners in all schools and colleges by the end of this financial year and at least 50% by the end of March 2025.[27]

Since September 2020, health education has been a statutory requirement in schools. It covers physical health and mental wellbeing; Statutory guidance on Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education (RSE) and Health Education (June 2019) explains that pupils are taught about common mental health problems (such as anxiety and depression), unrealistic expectations on body image, and schools may also choose to teach about eating disorders with support from the NHS or local specialist services. Further information is available in section 2 of the Library briefing on Personal, social, health and economic education in schools (England) (February 2021).

## House of Commons Library briefings

Further information, including on previous Government policy, is available in the House of Commons Library briefings on:

- Children and young people's mental health: policy and services (England), updated January 2024
- Mental health policy and services in England, updated October 2023

[26] Gov.uk, PM: mental health training for teachers will "make a real difference to children's lives", 27 June 2017

[27] PQ 4274 [Schools: Mental Health Services], 6 December 2023

# 2 Parliamentary materials

## 2.1 Parliamentary questions

**Eating Disorders**
**23 October 2023 | UIN 201519**

**Asked by: Rebecca Long Bailey**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, whether he plans to make financial support available for patients with (a) avoidant restrictive food intake disorder and (b) other eating disorders to help with the cost of living.

**Answering member: Maria Caulfield | Department: Department of Health and Social Care**

We have no plans to do so. Information on the support available to help with the cost of living is available at the following link:

https://www.gov.uk/cost-of-living

We have increased investment in children and young people's community eating disorder services every year, with this funding growing by £54 million in 2023/24. Over the five years from 2019/20, we will have also invested an extra £1 billion in community mental health care for adults with severe mental illness, including eating disorders, giving 370,000 more adults greater choice and control over their care and supporting them to live well in their communities.

**Free School Meals: Disability**
**21 March 2023 | UIN 163938**

**Asked by: Daisy Cooper**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment she has made of the potential merits of providing free school meal vouchers to those students who are eligible for free school meals but cannot access a school setting due to (a) disability, (b) Emotionally Based School Avoidance (EBSA), (c) Avoidant/Restrictive Food Intake Disorder (ARFID) or other factors.

**Answering member: Nick Gibb | Department: Department for Education**

The Education Act 1996 places a duty on maintained schools and academies to provide free school meals (FSM) to pupils of all ages that meet the criteria for eligibility and who are attending school during term time. The Act makes clear that a child must be registered at a publicly funded school as a condition of claiming FSM.

Local Authorities are funded to support children with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), including those who are unable to attend school on a long term basis. Parents are advised to liaise with Local Authorities to consider suitable alternatives in line with the guidance on long term illnesses, which is available at: https://www.gov.uk/illness-child-education.

### Eating Disorders: Young People

**01 February 2023 | UIN 129932**

**Asked by: Rachael Maskell**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, if he will make it his policy to remove age specific transition points between adolescent and adult services for young people with eating disorders for continuity of care.

**Answered by: Maria Caulfield | Department of Health and Social Care**

NHS England is developing whole pathway models of care for children and young people and adults with eating disorders with the aim of ensuring fewer inpatient admissions by 2024/25. Transition between services is being considered as part of this.

NHS England has also commissioned Academic Health Science Networks to take forward a project on transitions between children and young people's services and adults' services. The project seeks to map national and international best practice, with an aim to showcase a range of evidence-based approaches via an e-learning webinar that will be available to children and young people's eating disorder services and adult eating disorder services across England.

### Eating Disorders

**30 January 2023 | UIN 131428**

**Asked by: Tom Hunt**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps his Department is taking to support people with eating disorders.

**Answered by: Maria Caulfield | Department of Health and Social Care**

Under the NHS Long Term Plan, we will invest almost £1 billion extra in community mental health care for adults with severe mental illness by 2023/24. This will give 370,000 adults with severe mental illnesses, including eating disorders, greater choice and control over their care and support them to live well in their communities. As part of this we are expanding community eating disorder services capacity, including crisis care and intensive home treatment.

NHS England has also established 15 adult eating disorder provider collaboratives which cover the whole of England. These provider

collaboratives are working to redesign the pathway for adults with eating disorders to bring care closer to home.

Since 2016, investment in children and young people's community eating disorder services has risen every year, with an extra £54 million per year from 2022/23. This extra funding will enhance the capacity of community eating disorder teams across the country.

### Eating Disorders
**26 January 2023 | UIN 129935**

**Asked by: Rachael Maskell**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, if he will make an assessment of the implications for his policies of trends in the level of eating disorders; and what steps he is taking to help address the causes of eating disorders.

**Answered by: Maria Caulfield | Department of Health and Social Care**

There are no plans to make a specific assessment. However, we would expect, as part of new policy design and development, that all policies with implications for eating disorders should consider existing evidence and seek the views of experts and stakeholders.

In recognition of the rising demand for eating disorders services created by the pandemic, we invested £58 million in 2021/22 to support the expansion of adult community mental health services, including those for eating disorders. We also invested £79 million extra to expand children's mental health services in 2021/22, including enabling at least 2,000 more children and young people to access eating disorder services.

We know that eating disorders are complicated mental health conditions caused by a complex interaction of biological, psychological, and environmental factors. It is unclear exactly why someone develops an eating disorder.

### Eating Disorders: Medical Treatments
**26 January 2023 | UIN 129934**

**Asked by: Rachael Maskell**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, if he will make an assessment of the best practice course of treatment people with eating disorders.

**Answered by: Maria Caulfield | Department of Health and Social Care**

There are no plans to make an assessment. All decisions about treatment should be taken jointly between the clinician and the patient. Decisions

should be based on the best evidence available and national guidance where appropriate, so everyone gets the right treatments at the right time. We expect clinicians, commissioners, and providers to adhere to this guidance.

The National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) provides national clinical guidelines concerning the recognition and treatment of eating disorders. NHS England has also published separate guidance to support the provision and commissioning of eating disorder services for children and young people and adults. NHS England is currently refreshing this guidance, including to increase the focus on early identification and intervention.

# 3 News articles

"I lost my job. I lost my relationship. I lost my flat": shining a spotlight on ARFID for Eating Disorder Awareness Week 2024
Mancunian Matters
26 February 2024

UK eating disorder charity says calls from people with Arfid have risen sevenfold
The Guardian
26 February 2024

Your illness worsens – so care is cut off. This is the scandal playing out in eating disorder treatment
The Guardian
25 February 2024

Calls for nurse training to spot diabetes disordered eating [subscription required]
Nursing Times
23 January 2024

Sharp rise in teenage girls with eating disorders during Covid
BBC News
June 2023

NHS backlog 'fails children with eating disorders' [subscription required]
9 February 2023
The Times

The patients with treatable eating disorders who are dying before the NHS can help them
6 February 2023
Independent

Children and young people with an eating disorder waiting times
Nuffield Trust
4 May 2022

NHS treating record number of young people for eating disorders
7 March 2022
NHS England

# 4 Further information

Beat eating disorders

ARFID Awareness UK

APPG on eating disorders

National Eating Disorders Association

Healthy Outcomes for People with Eating disorders

Mental Health 360 | Children And Young People
The Kings Fund
21 February 2024

Type 1 diabetes and disordered eating: Parliamentary Inquiry (PDF)
Juvenile Diabetes Research Foundation
January 2024

Medical emergencies in Eating Disorders - Guidance on recognition and management
Royal College of Psychiatrists
October 2023

## 4.1 Select committee reports

The impact of body image on mental and physical health
Health and Social Care Committee's Second Report of Session 2022–23 | HC 114 2022-23
2 August 2022

Changing the perfect picture: an inquiry into body image
Women and Equalities Committee
Sixth report of session 2019-21 | HC 274
9 April 2021

Ignoring the Alarms follow-up: Too many avoidable deaths from eating disorders (PDF)
Public Administration and Constitutional Affairs Committee Seventeenth Report of Session 2017–19 | HC 855
18 June 2019

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